

FLOWER POWER

Preaching love, peace, and freedom, the hippie movement was a vocal and articulate subculture. Hippies first emerged in 1967 in San Francisco's Haight-Ashbury district, but the trend was soon adopted around the world. They not only took issue with the lifestyle of their parents, but also with racial inequality, sexual discrimination, and civil rights. Protest was at the heart of the movement, in particular against the US involvement in the Vietnam War (1965–73).

Hippie dress conveyed new beliefs: peace, interest in other cultures, and experimentation – especially with psychedelic drugs; bright clothing patterns attempted to reflect the LSD experience. The trend was anti-fashion and individuality was the key. Clothing, often second-hand, was customized with patchwork, embroidery, and appliquéd designs. Rustic imagery and celestial symbols reflected the strong pacifist and back-to-nature sentiments. The ethnic look dominated: shaggy Afghan coats, fringed suede jackets, kaftans, headscarves, and lots of beads. Patterns were psychedelic, and where possible fabrics were natural. Skirt lengths dropped to the floor in swaying maxis, though the mini was still worn, and flares, loon pants, and bell bottoms were in style for trousers. American blue jeans were no longer the preserve of the working class, and denim was worn by nearly everyone. The clothes and hairstyles of Indian and Afro-Caribbean communities were also incorporated. The fashion for unisex blossomed, and clothes were gender neutral with couples often wearing the same outfits.

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Today, nothing is out, because everything is in. Every costume from every era is now available to everyone.

MARSHALL MCLUHAN, *HARPER'S BAZAAR*, 1968

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BIRTH OF THE HIPPIE ▷

Hippies spreading flower power in Haight-Ashbury, San Francisco, USA, in 1968. Bright, patterned dresses were influenced by Indian fabrics and psychedelic experimentation.

